



Week 6

Topics covered in this module:

- Diversity in civic life: identity, privilege & representation
- Social inclusion vs social integration
- Social justice: equality vs equity
- Advocacy, activism & awareness campaigns
- Mobilizing public opinion
- Ethical advocacy: tokenism, saviorism & performative activism

M O D U L E 1

Diversity in Civic Life

Identity · Privilege · Representation

What we'll cover:

How identity shapes civic experience · What privilege means in practice · Why representation matters beyond numbers

What is Identity — and Why Does It Matter in Civic Life?

Identity refers to the social categories we belong to — race, gender, class, religion, ability, sexuality, nationality. These are not just personal traits; they shape how we experience society and who has access to power.

Identity Shapes Perspective

Our identities determine which problems we notice, which policies affect us most, and what issues feel urgent. A person with a disability experiences public transport policy very differently from someone without one.

Identity Affects Access

Not all identities are treated equally by civic institutions. Historically, certain groups were denied the vote, excluded from public life, or ignored in policymaking — shaping the inequalities we see today.

Intersectionality

Most people hold multiple identities at once. A Black woman faces different challenges than a white woman or a Black man — her experience is shaped by the combination of race and gender together. This concept is called intersectionality (Kimberlé Crenshaw, 1989).

Understanding Privilege

Privilege is a set of unearned advantages that people receive automatically based on their social identities — not because they worked for them, but because of who they are.

UNEARNED

Not based on individual merit or effort — automatically given at birth or through social position.

INVISIBLE

Those who have privilege often cannot see it. Like water to a fish — it's just 'how things are'.

SYSTEMIC

Built into laws, institutions, and social norms — not just individual attitudes or biases.

INTERSECTING

One can have privilege in one area (e.g. class) and face disadvantage in another (e.g. race).

Example: A qualified person from a marginalized background may be passed over for a job, while a less-qualified person from a privileged background gets it — not because of ability, but because of unconscious bias and systemic advantage.

Representation: More Than Just Numbers

Two Types of Representation

Descriptive Representation

Having people from a group present in an institution (e.g. a woman in parliament). Necessary but not sufficient.

Substantive Representation

Those representatives actually advocate for and advance the interests of their group. This is the goal.

Why Does It Matter?

Policies reflect lived experience

When decision-makers share the background of those affected, they are more likely to understand the real impact of policies.

Trust in institutions

Communities trust institutions more when they see themselves reflected in leadership — not as tokens, but in genuine roles.

Challenging systemic bias

Diverse representation helps expose and challenge assumptions baked into laws and institutions over generations.

Key idea: Representation is not about optics — it is about who shapes the rules that govern everyone's lives.

MODULE 2

Social Inclusion vs. Social Integration

Two different answers to the same question:

"How do marginalized groups fit into society?"

One asks the group to change. The other asks the system to change.

Social Integration vs. Social Inclusion: What's the Difference?

SOCIAL INTEGRATION

The group adapts to the system

Marginalized or minority groups are expected to adapt to the norms, values, and structures of the dominant culture. The system stays largely the same.

- ▶ Assumes the existing structure is the standard
- ▶ Asks newcomers or minorities to 'fit in'
- ▶ May require giving up cultural identity or language
- ▶ Success = becoming indistinguishable from the dominant group

Example: Immigrants are taught to assimilate – learn English only, adopt local customs, abandon traditional dress codes to succeed professionally.

SOCIAL INCLUSION

The system adapts to the group

Institutions and social systems are reformed to make space for diverse identities, ensuring everyone can participate fully without having to abandon who they are.

- ▶ Challenges and reforms existing structures
- ▶ Recognises and values diverse identities
- ▶ Removes systemic barriers to participation
- ▶ Success = everyone belongs on their own terms

Example: Schools provide multilingual support, prayer spaces, and flexible dress codes so students of all backgrounds can thrive without assimilating.

MODULE 3

Social Justice: Equality vs. Equity

Giving everyone the same thing is not the same as giving everyone what they need.

This distinction is at the heart of debates about fairness, justice, and policy design.

Equality vs. Equity — What's the Difference?

EQUALITY

Everyone receives the same resources, treatment, or opportunities — regardless of their starting point or individual needs.

✓ Strengths:

- + Simple and easy to understand
- + Treats everyone as formally equal
- + Works well when starting positions are similar

✗ Limitations:

- Ignores existing disadvantages
- Can reproduce or worsen inequality
- A 'fair' process can produce unfair outcomes

Classroom example: Every student gets the same textbook. But a student who cannot afford electricity at home cannot read it at night. Same resource, unequal access.

EQUITY

Resources and support are distributed based on what each person actually needs to reach the same outcome. People with more barriers receive more support.

✓ Strengths:

- + Addresses root causes of disadvantage
- + Produces fairer outcomes
- + Recognises that history shapes present conditions

✗ Limitations:

- More complex to implement
- Requires understanding of context and need
- Can face political resistance ('special treatment')

Classroom example: The student without electricity at home is given a printed copy with a battery-powered reading light. Different resources, equal opportunity to succeed.

Equity in Practice — Real-World Examples

Healthcare

Equality approach: Equal: Every patient gets 15 minutes with a doctor.

Equity approach: Equitable: Patients with chronic conditions get longer appointments; doctors are trained in language access for non-English speakers.

Education

Equality approach: Equal: Every school receives the same government funding per student.

Equity approach: Equitable: Schools in low-income areas receive additional funding for counsellors, meals, and learning support staff.

Employment

Equality approach: Equal: All job applicants go through the same interview process.

Equity approach: Equitable: Accommodations are made for disabled applicants; blind recruitment removes names to reduce racial bias.

Voting

Equality approach: Equal: All eligible citizens can vote during the same hours.

Equity approach: Equitable: Polling stations in working-class areas stay open longer; mail-in ballots are available for those who cannot take time off work.

Key insight: Equity does not mean everyone gets the same thing — it means everyone gets what they need to reach a fair outcome.

MODULE 4

Advocacy, Activism & Awareness Campaigns

Three tools for social change — similar goals, very different methods.

Understanding the difference helps you choose the right strategy for the right situation.

Three Approaches to Change: A Comparison

Advocacy

Working within the system

Systematic effort to influence decisions made by governments, institutions, or organisations. Advocates work within existing structures to change laws, policies, and funding priorities.

Common methods:

- ▶ Policy research & white papers
- ▶ Lobbying politicians and officials
- ▶ Legal challenges and court cases
- ▶ Coalition-building with NGOs and experts

Example: A disability rights NGO meets with government officials to argue for accessible building codes in new construction.

Activism

Challenging the system

Direct action to challenge and disrupt unjust power structures. Activists often work outside institutions, creating pressure through public disruption and mass mobilisation.

Common methods:

- ▶ Protests and marches
- ▶ Civil disobedience (sit-ins, blockades)
- ▶ Strikes and boycotts
- ▶ Grassroots community organising

Example: Students block the entrance to a university to demand divestment from fossil fuel companies.

Awareness Campaigns

Changing hearts and minds

Educational and media-driven efforts to shift public knowledge, attitudes, and cultural norms. These campaigns build the social foundation that makes policy change possible.

Common methods:

- ▶ Social media campaigns & hashtags
- ▶ Documentaries and storytelling
- ▶ Public art and performances
- ▶ School curricula and workshops

Example: #MeToo changed global conversation about sexual harassment – creating political pressure for policy reform.

Mobilizing Public Opinion

Persuasion · Coalition-Building · Legitimacy

Social change does not happen automatically. It requires deliberately winning people over, building broad alliances, and earning the trust of the public.

Mobilizing Public Opinion: Persuasion

Persuasion is the process of changing or strengthening beliefs, attitudes, and behaviours through communication. In civic contexts, it means building compelling cases for change.

Aristotle's Three Modes of Persuasion — still used today:

LOGOS

Logic & Evidence

Using data, research, and rational argument to convince. Facts, statistics, case studies, expert testimony.

e.g. Citing WHO data to argue for clean air policy.

ETHOS

Credibility & Trust

Establishing the speaker or organisation as trustworthy and credible. People support causes led by those they respect.

e.g. A respected doctor supporting a public health campaign.

PATHOS

Emotion & Story

Using emotional appeal and storytelling to connect with the audience on a human level. People act when they feel, not just when they think.

e.g. A refugee sharing their story to humanise immigration policy.

Effective persuasion uses all three modes — but must remain honest and respectful of opposing viewpoints.

Coalition-Building & Legitimacy

COALITION-BUILDING

A coalition is an alliance of different groups working together toward a shared goal, even if their broader agendas differ.

● **Why it matters:**

No single group has enough power to achieve major change alone. Broad coalitions signal to decision-makers that support is widespread and cross-sector.

● **How to build:**

Find overlapping interests even among unlikely allies. A union and an environmental group may disagree on many things but agree on workers' rights in a just transition.

● **Key challenge:**

Balancing different priorities and maintaining trust. Coalition partners must feel their voices are genuinely heard — not instrumentalised.

LEGITIMACY

Legitimacy is the belief that a cause, leader, or movement has the right to demand change. Without it, even well-funded campaigns fail.

● **Sources of legitimacy:**

Moral authority (representing affected communities), legal standing, democratic mandate, expert knowledge, and a track record of consistent action.

● **Accountability:**

Movements lose legitimacy when they are seen as hypocritical, corrupt, or unrepresentative. Leaders must be accountable to the communities they represent.

● **Transparent communication:**

Clearly explaining goals, methods, and funding builds public trust. Hidden agendas, even if well-intentioned, erode credibility.

Ethical Advocacy

Avoiding tokenism, saviorism, and performative activism

Good intentions are not enough. How you advocate matters as much as what you advocate for.

This module examines three common ethical failures in advocacy — and what genuine, respectful allyship looks like instead.

Tokenism: The Illusion of Inclusion

Tokenism is the practice of making only a symbolic or perfunctory effort to include members of marginalized groups — enough to appear diverse, but without giving them real power, voice, or influence.

What does it look like?

- ▶ Hiring one person from a minority group to signal diversity without changing workplace culture
- ▶ Inviting a marginalised community member to a single meeting, but decisions are already made
- ▶ Using images of diverse people in marketing while the leadership team remains homogeneous
- ▶ Asking one person to 'speak for' their entire group or community

Why is it harmful?

- ▶ It creates a false impression of inclusion while maintaining existing power structures
- ▶ It places a burden on token representatives — they must perform diversity without real support
- ▶ It can exhaust and alienate the very people you're trying to include
- ▶ It prevents genuine institutional change by substituting symbolism for substance

What to do instead?

- ▶ Involve marginalised communities early in decision-making, not just at consultation stages
- ▶ Ensure diverse representatives have real decision-making authority, not just advisory roles
- ▶ Evaluate outcomes: did diverse participation change the final decision?
- ▶ Create structural change — hiring practices, promotion pathways, culture audits

Saviorism: When 'Helping' Becomes Harmful

Saviorism (or the 'White Savior Complex') refers to a mindset where a privileged person or group positions themselves as the rescuer of a marginalised community — prioritising their own role and feeling of virtue over the actual needs and agency of those they claim to help.

Signs of saviorist thinking

- ▶ 'These people need me to save them' — centering the helper's role, not the community's needs
- ▶ Making decisions for a community without their input or consent
- ▶ Volunteering or donating primarily for social recognition or a sense of personal fulfilment
- ▶ Treating marginalised people as passive victims, not as experts of their own experience

Why it causes harm

- ▶ It undermines the agency and self-determination of the community — they become objects of charity, not agents of change
- ▶ It can perpetuate dependency rather than building local capacity and leadership
- ▶ It often reflects and reinforces power imbalances (e.g. colonial dynamics)
- ▶ It prioritises the helper's needs (to feel good) over the community's actual needs

What solidarity looks like instead

- ▶ Ask: 'What does this community say they need?' not 'What do I think they need?'
- ▶ Follow the leadership of those most affected by the issue
- ▶ Share resources, platforms, and power — don't just show up as the face of the campaign
- ▶ Stay committed even when it's not visible or celebrated — long-term solidarity, not short-term rescue

Performative Activism: Gesture Without Commitment

Performative activism refers to actions taken to demonstrate solidarity or values — primarily for social approval or image — without genuine commitment to long-term change. The audience of the action is the self or one's social circle, not the cause.

Common examples of performative activism

Blackout Tuesday (2020): Millions posted black squares on Instagram after George Floyd's murder — but many simultaneously posted hashtags that buried critical information and then moved on.

Disaster hashtags: Trending hashtags (#PrayForX) that create a momentary feeling of collective concern without any sustained attention or resources.

One-off donations after viral moments: Donating once after a shocking news story, then disengaging from the issue entirely.

What genuine commitment looks like

- **Consistent long-term engagement**
Showing up before and after media attention fades; building relationships with affected communities over time.
- **Measurable outcomes and accountability**
Setting concrete goals (e.g. get X policy changed, raise funds for Y) and publicly reporting on progress.
- **Institutional change, not just individual gestures**
Pushing for structural reforms — policies, budgets, legislation — not just cultural statements.
- **Listening and learning**
Regularly seeking feedback from those most affected and adapting approach based on their guidance.

Ask yourself: Is this action for the cause — or for how it makes me look?

Key Takeaways: What You Should Know

01

Identity shapes civic experience

Race, gender, class, and other identities affect how people experience civic life and which policies affect them. Recognising this is essential for genuine engagement.

02

Inclusion ≠ Integration

Integration asks marginalised people to conform to the system. Inclusion asks the system to reform itself. These have fundamentally different implications for belonging and justice.

03

Equity over Equality

Treating everyone the same ignores unequal starting points. Equitable policy gives people what they need to reach a fair outcome — not just the same resource.

04

Know your tool: advocacy, activism, or awareness

Each has different methods, audiences, and risks. Effective change-makers understand when to use which approach — and often combine all three.

05

Public opinion must be won — ethically

Persuasion, coalition-building, and legitimacy are strategic tools. But they must be grounded in honesty, accountability, and respect for those affected.

06

Avoid tokenism, saviorism, and performance

Good intentions are not enough. Genuine allyship means giving real power to affected communities, following their leadership, and committing to long-term action.